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CART 263 section A

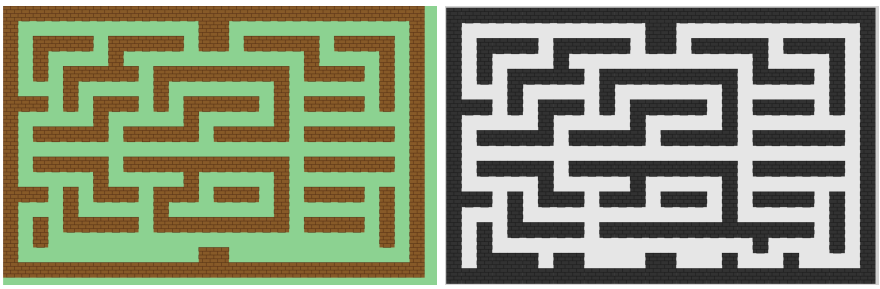
Project 1 - Artists' Statement

Project URL: https://sleepyrayray.github.io/project-1/

Project Process

Our project was first to be a reversed Pac-Man game with unpredictable sounds, reflecting the difficulty to earn the copyrights for songs content creators often face. The Pac-Man idea came up because a member of the group (Jason) did a similar project before. It was a website inspired from the *Matrix* movie where the user had to choose a pill and was confronted with different choices to get back to reality. We thought that one pill would put the user on a maze map. Then we got the idea of making it look like a Pac-Man game, a character chasing another one, making the graphisms doable on javascript, without using p5. At first, we simply got the idea to reverse the Pac-Man concept, the player playing the ghost that is trying to escape from Pac-Man, while stealing his food. Here, the sound effects would be incoherent, definitely off topic with the actions of the ghost, like the sound of a frog burping while the character would be catching an item for example. This idea of ironically using copyrighted material only came up during the first day the project was given. It was our first seed. But we needed a second seed, another reference from the readings. So we dived into it and... Data Collection and Surveillance Capitalism came up. Keeping the same main idea, with a map and a character hunting another one catching items, we replaced the Pac-Man idea by a thief vs police kind of subway surfer game. The thief stealing data, in reference to surveillance capitalism. How we processed this? Given that we are a group of 3, we

made a common github repository to make the changes merge more easily in the main code, using different branches that can merge pieces of code after fetching and pulling from the github desktop. We figured out it was the most efficient way for us to work on our project without having synchronization problems. Connecting the same repository to 3 different laptops was one of the main difficulties we encountered. Regarding the work itself, while Jason worked on the collectibles and Ray designed the police and thief and coded their movements, Yann took charge of designing the map and finding the sound effects. The map's design changed after our main idea of the game changed. It improved; new colours, new blocks and gameplay music was added.



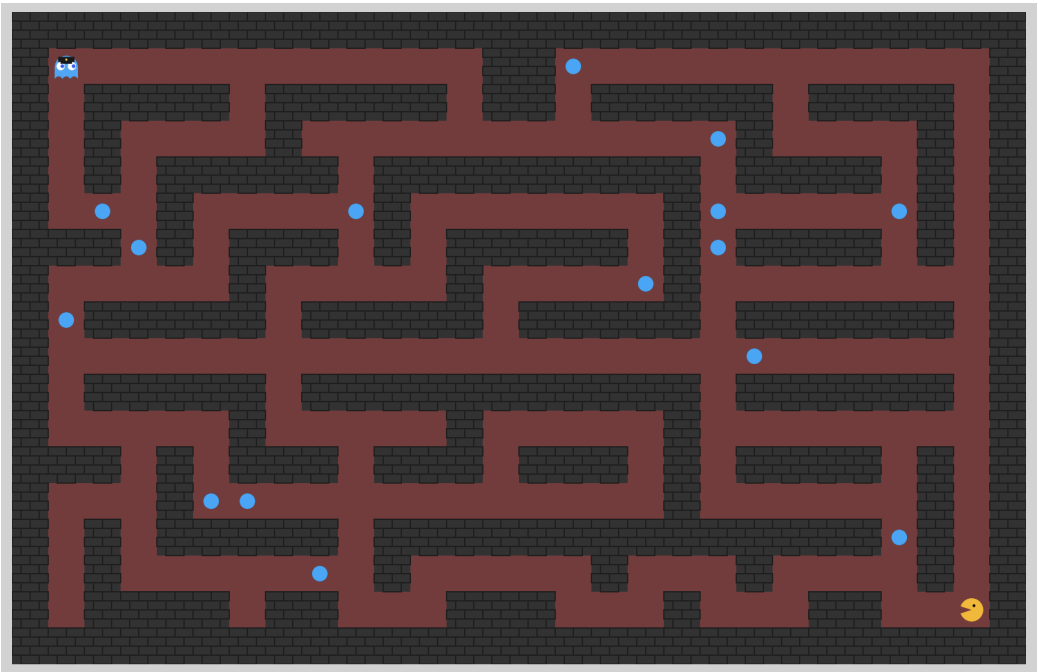


Figure 1 shows the original design of the maze map and the updated versions.

Our ideas include ironically demonstrating how the privacy of copyrighted materials can be a difficulty and showing how our data are taken away from us in reference to data collection and surveillance capitalism that came up during in class talks and discord calls. They are both represented in the game in very straightforward ways.

Copyright

One of the main topics in our project is copyright. Copyright exists to protect people's creative expression of their own ideas and provide inspiration for people to create new works. Without these protections, others could easily steal a creator's work without permission or compensation and take advantage of the value of the original creation. Although copyright laws are made by governments, the general principle is shared worldwide: creators' control how their works are used and adapted, and unauthorized use may be restricted unless permission is granted.[1] Our work is inspired by the famous Pac-Man game mechanically, started with basic settings: a content thief is hunted by a righteous police who protects the creation of an independent creator. The maze in our game symbolizes the digital world: complex and full of information that needs to be protected. The chase represents conflict between control and violation as well as plagiarism. The game outcome does not only depend on speed and strategy but also on the rules that define what is allowed and what is not. The collectibles in the game are no longer just beans but information that are (or will be) stolen by the thief. If the thief is not stopped, it would move faster which means the inappropriate behavior leads to no consequences and the thief will be encouraged to consume more content that is not

[1] Creative Commons, "2.1 Copyright Basics," Accessed March 2, 2026, https://creativecommons.org/course/cc-cert-edu/unit-2-copyright-law/2-1-copyright-basics/.

protected. The main goal of our game is to encourage people to focus on giving respect to others' own creativity and help to prevent content theft from happening to all of us. We realized that copyright is not just about stopping theft through this project. It is also about defining relationships between creators, users, and entire society. By designing the metaphorical game, we were able to explore information protection and respect to independent thinking in the digital world. By combining the protection of copyright with options for diversity, appropriate creative commons helps build a richer global commons of knowledge and creativity that benefits creators and users alike.[2] Our goal is to transform the classic Pac-Man into an inspirational project that shows our statement to society: an individual's independent creativity is always sacred and should be protected.

Data Collection

In our project, data collection is the theme and the main action of the game. The thief's job is to move through the maze and pick up data collectibles, while the police ghost tries to stop and catch him. We designed it this way because collecting data in reality feels like a chase where information moves through systems, people are after it for different reasons, and there are rules about who is allowed to have access and take it. By making data visible objects on the map, we were able to make an abstract idea easier to visualize. Each of the collectibles represent a piece of personal information that is valuable. When the thief grabs it, the game rewards him through gaining temporary movement speed. It also increases pressure because the police ghost is still around. That tension is part of our point, which is to say that collecting data is super risky and

[2] Creative Commons, "What We Do - Creative Commons," May 20, 2025, https://creativecommons.org/about/.

harmful depending how it's done. We also want players to notice that not all data collection is the same. Some data is meant to be shared and reused in a legal way. The Open Data Handbook describes open data as something that can be freely used, reused and redistributed by anyone with only basic requirements.[3] This is an important idea for our project. Open data is about consent, transparency, and permission. Our thief represents the opposite side where he takes data without permission. In that sense, the collectibles represent information being turned into something to grab, to loot, and to win with. The idea is that the information doesn't belong to the player (thief) who takes it. The police ghost represents the other side like protection, security, and the idea that there are consequences for unauthorized access. We connect this directly to the real legal framing of data theft. In Canada's Criminal Code, unauthorized use of a computer is treated as an indictable offence and it can lead to serious penalties, which includes imprisonment for up to 10 years.[4] Our game is not a perfect simulation of the law, but we are using the chase mechanic to express the idea that stealing data is a form of breaking the law and boundaries. The emotional aspect of the game is also important. As the thief, collecting data in the game can be exciting because it gives a temporary speed boost, which can be an advantage. He can escape faster and be farther away from the police ghost who moves at a constant speed. However, it can also create stress because the thief still needs to keep moving and have to pick up all data collectibles on the map to win the game. We designed this kind of pressure on purpose. It reflects how stealing data can feel rewarding, but it is still dangerous and illegal. As the police ghost, the player experiences a different kind of tension. Since their speed never changes, they

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[3] "What Is Open Data?," n.d., https://opendatahandbook.org/guide/en/what-is-open-data/.
[4] Legislative Services Branch, "Consolidated Federal Laws of Canada, Criminal Code," October 10, 2025, https://laws-lois.justice.gc.ca/eng/acts/C-46/section-342.1.html.

have to focus on strategy. This reflects the idea that stopping bad guys is mostly about planning and timing, rather than getting stronger. By putting both contrasting characters in our game, we encourage players to think about how rules, ethics, and power can shape what data collection is all about.

Bibliography

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